was either ignored or silenced." In a major March 1959 speech, Castro identified the "battle to end racial discrimination in the workplace" as one of the four major economic issues facing the Revolution.[1]

The revolutionary government moved quickly to outlaw racial discrimination. Four years after *Brown v. Board of Education* ruled segregated schools unlawful in the United States, and a year before the Congress of Racial Equality began its campaign to desegregate lunch counters in the southern United States, Cuba banned all public and private forms of racial exclusion.

Other early reforms that were not specifically focused on race also addressed the country's racial inequalities. Because Afro-Cubans were disproportionately poor, they benefited disproportionately from the economic reforms that redistributed the country's resources. Likewise, because Cubans of color were barely represented among the country's elites, few were threatened by the redistributions, and few participated in the exodus of the professional classes to Miami between 1959 and 1962. The white exodus created a Cuba that was progressively darker hued, and more racially equal.

Afro-Cuban scholar Pedro Serviat heralded the Revolution's structural approach to overcoming racial inequality in his 1986 book *El problema negro en Cuba y su solución definitiva – The Black Problem in Cuba and its Definitive Solution*. Even as the book appeared, though, the Third Congress of Cuba's Communist Party was acknowledging that in fact there had been no "definitive solution" as it called for measures to increase the presence of women and blacks in the Party's leadership.

As Serviat explained revolutionary policy in the first decades:

> The main gain was to guarantee the right to work for all citizens under equal conditions. This was achieved with some concrete measures. The Revolution opened secretarial schools, with priority for former domestics, the majority black. Many of them later went on to work in banks as secretaries, clerks, etc. The opening of catering, management and foreign service schools enabled thousands of black and white citizens of humble origin to train in various fields… The beaches, sports and recreational centers were nationalized… The Revolution put culture at the service of the people; revindicated